EDIGHA FRANCISCA LITERARY SOLUTIONS

Author Marketing Preparation Guide

Seven questions to answer before commissioning book marketing work, and the documents each answer should produce. The questions are ordered so that each one prepares the next. Answering them is not a marketing campaign. It is the ground on which a campaign can stand.

EDIGHA FRANCISCA · AUTHOR GROWTH STRATEGIST

01 Objective

PRODUCES AN OBJECTIVES SHEET

THE QUESTION

What does success for this book actually look like?

Not a vague aspiration. A specific number for a specific time. The answer shapes everything that follows, because a book aiming for fifty reviews in sixty days is marketed one way and a book aiming for a single mention in a specific community is marketed another. If the objective is not decided, no marketing work can be judged effective or ineffective, because there was never a standard against which to judge it.

> WORKED EXAMPLE
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> *"By the end of the first sixty days, I want fifty honest reviews and two hundred preorders. I do not need the book to appear in any bestseller list. I want it to find the readers who will finish it and recommend it, because that is the audience I am building toward for the second book."*

02 Audience

PRODUCES A READER PROFILE

THE QUESTION

Which readers must be reached first?

Not all readers of the genre. The specific subset most likely to open the sample, finish the sample, and buy the book. This is not a demographic. It is a description of a reader in a specific situation, looking for a specific book. The description that works for that reader is different from the description that works for a broader audience, and the choice between them is the choice between a book that reaches some readers well and a book that reaches no readers at all.

> WORKED EXAMPLE
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> *"The first readers are women aged thirty five to fifty five who read psychological thrillers on Kindle, follow two or three book reviewers on Instagram, and have recently finished something by Freida McFadden or Lisa Jewell. They read in the evening and finish a book in three or four sittings. They are looking for a book that pulls them in within the first page."*

03 Promise

PRODUCES A POSITIONING SENTENCE

THE QUESTION

What does this book promise that the books beside it do not?

Not the plot, not the premise, but the specific feeling or insight the reader will have that no comparable title can give them. The promise is the spine of every piece of marketing copy that follows: the description, the tagline, the review pitch, the social caption. A book without a specific promise is a book that cannot be recommended in one sentence, and a book that cannot be recommended in one sentence does not travel.

> WORKED EXAMPLE
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> *"This book is for readers who have finished a psychological thriller and felt that the twist came at the cost of the characters.* This is a thriller where the twist is earned by the people, not the plot*. It is the same pace as the bestsellers in the category, with characters you carry out of the book."*

04 Comparable titles

PRODUCES A SHELF OF COMPARABLES

THE QUESTION

Which books will this book be compared with?

Every book enters a shelf of titles the reader already knows. Naming those titles is not a marketing claim. It is a positioning exercise, because a book's place in the market is decided by the books it is sold beside. Three to five titles, chosen deliberately, reveal the shelf. A book without named comparables is a book without a place.

> WORKED EXAMPLE
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> *"The three titles closest to this book are The Housemaid by Freida McFadden, The Silent Patient by Alex Michaelides, and The Girl on the Train by Paula Hawkins. My book sits between The Housemaid and The Silent Patient in tone: more character driven than McFadden, more pace driven than Michaelides."*

05 Budget and time

PRODUCES A WORKING PLAN

THE QUESTION

What resources are available, honestly?

A book marketed with two hundred dollars is not a failure. A book marketed with two hundred dollars and the expectation of a five thousand dollar return is a failure, because the plan was not built around the resources. Budget and time are not limitations of marketing. They are the ground the plan has to stand on. A plan that assumes resources that do not exist is not a plan.

> WORKED EXAMPLE
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> *"I have five hundred dollars for the first six months and four hours a week to spend on this. My time is limited, so the plan has to be centred on things I can do once and forget: metadata, description, A plus content. Reviews have to be requested but not manufactured. Advertising has to be tested in small amounts, not committed to in one large amount."*

06 Judgement

PRODUCES A MEASUREMENT PLAN

THE QUESTION

How will success be measured, and when?

A book marketed with no measurement plan is a book marketed on faith. Measurement is not a spreadsheet. It is a small number of signals, checked at named intervals, that answer one question: is the strategy working? If the answer is yes, the strategy continues. If the answer is no, the strategy changes. Without the signals, the only available answer is "it feels like it might be working," which is not an answer.

> WORKED EXAMPLE
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> *"I will check three signals on the first of every month for six months: the BSR rank in my primary category, the number of reviews, and the position the book appears at for my top three target keywords. If reviews are not growing after month three, the description or the categories are the likely cause, not the price. If reviews are growing but BSR is not, the book is being bought and not being read, and I have a different problem."*

07 The next book

PRODUCES A CATALOGUE PLAN

THE QUESTION

What happens after this book succeeds?

The most important question, and the one most often skipped. A book marketed without a plan for the next book is a book that has to succeed on its own, which is a harder ask than it needs to be. If the next book is named, then the marketing of this book can build toward it: the author page can lead to it, the follow button can prepare the reader, the reviews can be gathered with a list that will still exist when the next one launches.

> WORKED EXAMPLE
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> *"I have the first draft of a second book ready, and I want this one to bring readers who will follow into that. Every review I collect should be from someone who might read book two. Every reader who presses follow is a reader I do not have to find again. The marketing of this book is the beginning of the marketing of the next one, not the whole of it."*